

remarkable feature of the island—as “Fingal’s Cave.” It is one of the first notable examples of a “concert overture”: one that is freestanding rather than used as an introduction to a ballet, opera, or other performance.



#### **FINGAL’S CAVE**

The sight of the octagonal basalt columns of Fingal’s Cave on the island of Staffa in the Inner Hebrides inspired the famous opening theme of Mendelssohn’s overture *The Hebrides*, a work he dedicated to Frederick William IV of Prussia.

A leg injury in a carriage accident delayed Mendelssohn’s return to Germany and caused him to miss Fanny’s wedding, which was held in Berlin on October 3, 1829. The following year, although he was still only 21, he was offered the position of head of the music department at Berlin University. However, he turned it down as he wanted to continue seeing the world, and he spent much of the next two years traveling—in Austria, Italy, Switzerland, France, and England again. During this time he met several famous musicians, including Berlioz in Rome and Chopin in Paris.